

wholly true," says Indu Prakash Singh of ActionAid India, theme leader, shelter & housing. "We're talking about people who have been raped or assaulted as children, who had bad marriages, lost loved ones, were thrown out of families, jobs or suffered other kinds of indignities."

The story of India's vagrants is way too complex. There is no proper enumeration of beggars in the country. Moreover, the number of women and children is zooming. The 1931 Census mentioned just 16 per cent women beggars. The figure shot up to 49 per cent in 2001. One among them is

Emergency. That changed with the colonial rule. To the Victorians, beggary embodied laziness and moral degeneration. Colonial laws held a beggar punishable for his condition. The newly-independent nation imbibed this Anglo-Saxon attitude towards poverty. "In the new millennium, the Government doesn't want them lying around. Middle class India regards them as a nuisance."

"India's beggary laws are a throwback to the centuries-old European vagrancy laws, which instead of addressing the socio-economic issues make the poor criminally responsible

for their position," says ace lawyer, Ram Jethmalani. Consider the definition of the term 'beggar'. The law describes a beggar as anyone who appears 'poor'. Depending on the whim of a police officer, a ragpicker or a construction labourer, who has never begged in his life, can be picked up at random and incarcerated in a beggars' home for up to three years. "The anti-beggar legislation is aimed at wiping the desperately poor off city radars so that they don't prick our collective conscience," he says.

Activists who routinely encounter hostility, even violence, from rough

85% beggars have no information about beggar homes

Rs 180 CR is the worth of Mumbai beggars

14% beggars have no expectation from the government

Kusum Devi, 45, who took to the streets after her army jawan husband died in a "war" (she doesn't know which) and the family threw her out. "To live on the streets means *beizzati* (humiliation)," she says. "The policeman beats you with his baton. Any ruffian sits next to you and runs his hands over your body." She survived all that for 30 years before she was rescued by the volunteers of ActionAid. Just a little distance from Kusum Devi's old haunt in Delhi's Barakhamba Road, little Sapna and her cronies prance around, circus-style, with painted cheeks and drums. Sapna stays with her aunt, makes about Rs 70 a day and remits the sum to her parents—landless labourers in Bilaspur, Madhya Pradesh. She belongs to India's 10 million street children; one of Delhi's 80 per cent vagrant children who claim, "Nobody has forced me to beg," yet have no control over their income.

The biggest problem, however, lies in the changing attitude towards beggars. "Traditionally, begging has been an accepted way of life in India," says Upendra Baxi, former vice-chancellor of Delhi University and a lawyer by training. "Giving alms to the needy was built into the social fabric," says Baxi who defended the legal rights of beggars in court during the



OUTCAST:
Shelters are like
prisons for beggars

VIKRAM SHARMA

sleepers agree. "Those who have been on the streets for years get very uncomfortable when they are suddenly in a confined space," says Atul Haksar of Karuna Welfare, a Mumbai organisation working on beggars. Their fear turns into resentment and only a few last more than a couple of months in a shelter. "There are provisions for vocational training in the government-run beggar homes. But these are worse than the third-rate jails, where convicts may be incarcerated for up to 10 years," he adds.

Can India fix the problem? Behra doesn't think so. It's two weeks since he has returned from Varanasi. Begging there was good. He shows off a bottle of cheap country liquor tucked into his sack. He's still telling tales. But they have now taken on a darker tone with him playing the victim. The villains, inevitably, are representatives of the state—policemen who beat him up for no reason and doctors who don't give the medicines he needs. "Governments hurt people," he says, recounting years of abuse he endured (or did he?) in a beggar home long ago. "The *sarkar* thinks short term," he says wisely. Finding long-term solutions for people like Behra may be the biggest hurdle on India's road ahead. Is the nation ready to face the truth? ■